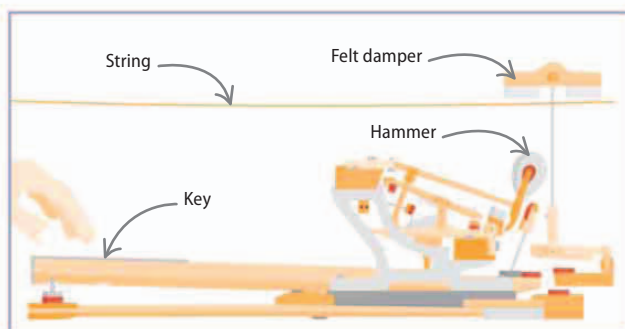


Keyboards

Though keyboards seem to be instruments in their own right, in reality they activate sound produced by other means—by strings (piano, harpsichord), by wind (organ), and by electronics (keyboards and electric pianos).

The piano

The most popular of all instruments, the modern pianoforte ("soft-loud") has its origins in the early 18th-century fortepiano ("loud-soft"). It features as a soloist in recitals and concertos, and is central to most chamber music.



△ Hammer mechanism

When a key is pressed, the hammer strikes the strings and a felt "damper" is lifted, allowing the strings to vibrate. When the key is released, the damper returns to its initial position, preventing further vibrations.

REAL WORLD

Inside a piano

While the strings in a grand piano run horizontally, they are vertical in an upright piano. Made of steel, the strings are secured to the frame at high tension by pins. Most notes have two or three strings tuned identically to add power. When the "una corda" (one string) pedal is pressed, the hammers move sideways, striking only one of the strings.



SEE ALSO

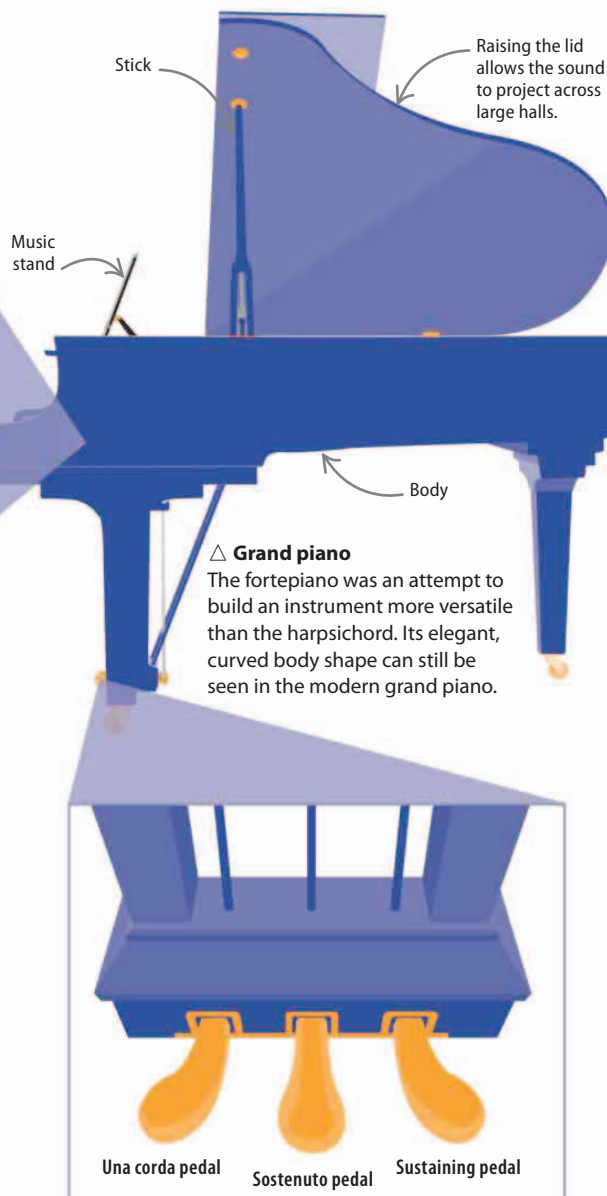
◀ 16–17 The piano keyboard

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△ Piano pedals

Depressing the sustaining pedal joins sounds together smoothly, while the middle pedal sustains only certain pitches. The una corda pedal softens the sound.